

COVER TO COVER

PROPHETS BEFORE, DURING AND AFTER CAPTIVITY

BEFORE THE ASSYRIAN CAPTIVITY

(Northern Kingdom of Israel)

These prophets ministered while Israel still existed as a nation. Their primary message was:

"Repent or God will use Assyria to judge you."

Elijah (c. 870–850 BC)

- Ministered during the reign of Ahab and Jezebel.
- Did not write a prophetic book.
- Called Israel back to covenant faithfulness.
- Famous for Mount Carmel.
- **Before the Assyrian captivity.**

Elisha (c. 850–800 BC)

- Did not write a prophetic book.
- Performed many miracles.
- Ministered to the northern kingdom before its fall.
- **Before the Assyrian captivity.**

Jonah (c. 780 BC)

- Sent to Nineveh, the capital of Assyria.
- Warned Israel indirectly by showing that even Israel's future enemy could repent.
- Written **before** Israel fell.

Amos (c. 760 BC)

- Preached primarily to the Northern Kingdom.
- Warned that injustice and idolatry would bring destruction.
- **Written about 35–40 years before Assyria conquered Israel.**

Hosea (c. 755–715 BC)

- Ministered during Israel's final decades.
- His marriage illustrated Israel's spiritual adultery.
- Continued preaching almost until Samaria fell.

- Written before and possibly during the final years leading up to the Assyrian conquest (722 BC).

BEFORE THE BABYLONIAN CAPTIVITY

(Southern Kingdom of Judah)

These prophets warned Judah for more than a century that Babylon was coming.

Isaiah (c. 740–680 BC)

- Ministered over 100 years before Babylon destroyed Jerusalem.
- Predicted both the Babylonian captivity and the future return.
- Mostly **before captivity**.

Micah (c. 735–700 BC)

- Contemporary of Isaiah.
- Warned Judah and Israel.
- Predicted Jerusalem's destruction.
- **Before captivity**.

Joel

The exact date is debated.

Many scholars place Joel:

- before the exile

Others:

- after the exile

The evidence is not conclusive.

Nahum (c. 660 BC)

- Prophesied the destruction of Nineveh.
- Encouraged Judah that Assyria's power would end.
- **Before Babylonian captivity**.

Habakkuk (c. 609–605 BC)

- Lived just before Babylon invaded.
- Questioned why God would use Babylon.
- **Immediately before captivity.**

Zephaniah (c. 640–609 BC)

- During King Josiah's reign.
- Warned that judgment was coming.
- **Before captivity.**

Jeremiah (c. 627–580 BC)

Jeremiah spans **all three stages**:

- Before captivity
- During the Babylonian invasions
- After Jerusalem fell

He watched Jerusalem burn and remained with those left in Judah before eventually being taken to Egypt.

Obadiah

This is another debated book.

Most scholars place Obadiah:

- immediately after Jerusalem fell (586 BC)

His prophecy condemns Edom for rejoicing over Judah's destruction.

So he wrote:

- **just after the fall of Jerusalem**, but before the restoration.

DURING THE BABYLONIAN CAPTIVITY

(The Exile)

These prophets actually ministered while the Jews were living in Babylon.

Ezekiel (593–571 BC)

- ✓ During captivity

- Taken to Babylon in the second deportation (597 BC)
- Ministered among the Jewish exiles.
- Never returned to Judah.
- Explained why judgment had come.
- Gave hope for Israel's future restoration.

Daniel (605–536 BC)

✓ During captivity

- Taken in the first deportation.
- Served in Babylon and later Persia.
- Encouraged faithful living in exile.
- Revealed God's plan for the kingdoms of the world and the coming Messiah.

AFTER THE BABYLONIAN CAPTIVITY

(After the Return)

Babylon fell in 539 BC.

King Cyrus allowed the Jews to return beginning in 538 BC.

These prophets ministered after many Jews returned to Jerusalem.

Haggai (520 BC)

✓ After captivity

- Encouraged rebuilding the Temple.
- Rebuked the people for building their own houses while neglecting God's house.

Zechariah (520–518 BC)

✓ After captivity

- Encouraged rebuilding.
- Pointed to the coming Messiah.
- Contained many apocalyptic visions.

Malachi (c. 430 BC)

✓ After captivity

- Last Old Testament prophet.
- Addressed spiritual complacency after the Temple had been rebuilt.
- Called the people back to wholehearted covenant faithfulness.
- Pointed ahead to the coming of John the Baptist and the Messiah.

Timeline Summary

Time Period	Prophets
Before Assyria (Northern Kingdom)	Elijah, Elisha, Jonah, Amos, Hosea
Before Babylon (Southern Kingdom)	Isaiah, Micah, Joel (likely), Nahum, Habakkuk, Zephaniah, Jeremiah (began here)
During Babylonian Captivity	Jeremiah (continued), Ezekiel, Daniel
Immediately After Jerusalem Fell	Obadiah (most likely)
After the Return from Exile	Haggai, Zechariah, Malachi

One helpful way to teach this is to think of the prophets as God's voices at four key moments:

1. **Before the exile** — "Repent, or judgment is coming."
2. **During the exile** — "The judgment has come, but God has not abandoned you."
3. **After the exile** — "Return to the Lord, rebuild, and prepare for the coming Messiah."
4. **Throughout all three stages** — Jeremiah uniquely bridges the transition from warning, to witnessing the destruction, to ministering after Jerusalem's fall, making him the prophet who experienced nearly the entire Babylonian crisis firsthand.

This framework makes it much easier for students to place each prophetic book within the historical narrative of **2 Kings**, where the fall of Israel (722 BC) and the fall of Judah (586 BC) serve as the major turning points in Israel's history.